

RAG-Based Medical Report Simplification System

A Project Report submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements
for the award of the degree of

**Bachelor of Technology in
Computer Science and Engineering**

by

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Semester: 6th



**Department of Computer Science and Engineering
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(An Institute of National Importance by an Act of Parliament)

MAY 2026

BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the project report entitled “**RAG-Based Medical Report Simplification System**” submitted by **Satvik Kesarwani** bearing the **MIS No: 112315166**, **Sarthak Takle** bearing the **MIS No: 112315165**, **Aryan Shinde** bearing the **MIS No: 112315172**, **Prisha Gupta** bearing the **MIS No: 112315143** and **Prince Gaikwad** bearing the **MIS No: 112315142**, in completion of their project work under the guidance of **Dr. Priyank Jain** is accepted for the project report submission in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of the degree of Bachelor of Technology in the Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Indian Institute of Information Technology, Pune (IIIT Pune), during the academic year 2025-26.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

This project would not have been possible without the help and cooperation of many. We would like to thank the people who helped us directly and indirectly in the completion of this project work.

First and foremost, we would like to express our gratitude to our Honourable Director, **Prof. Vineet Kansal**, for providing his kind support in various aspects. We would like to express our gratitude to our project guide **Dr. Priyank Jain, Department of CSE**, for providing excellent guidance, encouragement, inspiration, constant and timely support throughout this **B.Tech Project**. We would like to express our gratitude to the Head of Department **Dr. Bhupendra Singh, Department of CSE**, for providing his kind support in various aspects. We would also like to thank all the faculty members in the **Department of CSE** and our classmates for their steadfast and strong support and engagement with this project.

We extend our sincere thanks to our families for their unwavering encouragement and patience throughout this journey. Their belief in our abilities has been a constant source of motivation.

ABSTRACT

Medical reports are essential documents that communicate critical health information between healthcare providers and patients. However, these reports are predominantly written in dense clinical terminology, complex biomedical language, and technical abbreviations that are largely incomprehensible to the average patient. This communication gap creates significant challenges: patients struggle to understand their own diagnoses, lab results, and treatment plans, leading to anxiety, poor health literacy, and suboptimal healthcare decision-making. Existing solutions either require manual interpretation by medical professionals or provide raw report access without meaningful simplification, leaving patients confused and disempowered about their own health status.

This project presents a RAG-Based Medical Report Simplification System — an intelligent, end-to-end pipeline that converts complex medical documents into clear, patient-friendly explanations. The proposed system integrates Optical Character Recognition (OCR) for text extraction from PDF and image-based medical reports, Natural Language Processing (NLP) for medical entity recognition and semantic parsing, and Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) combined with Large Language Models (LLMs) for context-aware simplification. The RAG component retrieves authoritative medical knowledge including normal reference ranges, clinical interpretations, and disease associations from trusted sources such as MedlinePlus and Testing.com, ensuring that generated explanations are factually grounded and medically accurate.

Key contributions of this work include:

- (1) an integrated end-to-end pipeline combining OCR, NLP, RAG, and LLM technologies for medical text simplification;
- (2) a patient-centric design focused on readability and health literacy improvement;
- (3) automated abnormal value detection with visual risk highlighting;
- (4) a comprehensive evaluation framework using BLEU, ROUGE, Flesch Reading Ease, NER precision/recall, and user satisfaction metrics.

Keywords: Medical Text Simplification, Retrieval-Augmented Generation, Optical Character Recognition, Natural Language Processing, Large Language Models, Health Literacy, Patient-Centric Healthcare.

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Abbreviations used:

OCR : Optical Character Recognition	API : Application Programming Interface
NLP : Natural Language Processing	GPU : Graphics Processing Unit
RAG : Retrieval-Augmented Generation	WBC : White Blood Cell
LLM : Large Language Model	Hb : Hemoglobin
NER : Named Entity Recognition	RBC : Red Blood Cell
BLEU : Bilingual Evaluation	GPT : Generative Pre-trained Transformer
Understudy	ViT : Vision Transformer
ROGUE : Recall-Oriented Understudy	RAM : Random Access Memory
for Gisting Evaluation	CPU : Central Processing Unit

Chapter 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Overview of Work

This project addresses the critical challenge of medical report comprehension by developing an intelligent, automated system that transforms complex clinical documents into accessible, patient-friendly language. Medical reports including pathology results, radiology summaries, discharge summaries, and lab reports are foundational to patient care and health communication. However, these documents are authored for clinical professionals and rely heavily on specialized terminology, abbreviations, quantitative reference ranges, and implicit clinical reasoning that lay patients cannot reasonably interpret. The result is a systemic information asymmetry where patients possess their health data yet lack the cognitive tools to understand it.

The proposed RAG-Based Medical Report Simplification System is an end-to-end software solution designed to eliminate this barrier. The system accepts medical reports in PDF or image format as input. In the first stage, Optical Character Recognition (OCR) technology specifically the Tesseract OCR engine extracts raw textual content from scanned documents, handling variations in scan quality, font types, and document layouts. The extracted text is then processed by a Natural Language Processing (NLP) module built on spaCy and SciSpacy, which identifies medical entities including test names, disease conditions, anatomical references, and numeric values such as lab measurements.

The core innovation of this system lies in its Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) architecture. Rather than relying solely on the parametric knowledge of a Large Language Model (LLM), the system queries a structured medical knowledge base to retrieve contextually relevant information. This knowledge base contains normal reference ranges for laboratory tests (e.g., hemoglobin 13–17 g/dL, WBC 4,000–11,000 / μ L), clinical interpretations of abnormal values, disease associations, and plain-language medical explanations sourced from authoritative repositories such as MedlinePlus and Testing.com. The retrieved knowledge is combined with the patient's specific report values to construct a rich, contextualized prompt for the LLM.

The LLM which may be implemented using GPT-family models or open-source alternatives such as LLaMA then generates a personalized, simplified explanation that:

- (a) explains what each test measures in plain language;
- (b) compares the patient's values against normal ranges;
- (c) highlights abnormal values with risk indicators;
- (d) provides possible clinical interpretations without making definitive diagnoses

(e) suggests appropriate next steps or questions to discuss with a healthcare provider.

The entire pipeline is exposed through a modern web interface built with React and Tailwind CSS, supported by a Node.js/Flask backend that orchestrates the processing steps.

1.2 Motivation of Work

The motivation for this project stems from multiple interconnected real-world needs observed in contemporary healthcare delivery. First, health literacy remains a global challenge. According to numerous health communication studies, a significant percentage of patients cannot comprehend basic medical instructions, let alone interpret laboratory reports. When patients receive a blood test report showing “WBC: 13,000 / μ L” with no explanation, they are left to search the internet, where they may encounter misinformation or alarmist content. This knowledge gap leads to unnecessary anxiety, delayed follow-up care, and poor adherence to treatment protocols.

Second, clinical professionals face severe time constraints. Physicians, nurses, and lab technicians operate under heavy workloads and cannot provide detailed, personalized explanations for every report to every patient. While doctors summarize findings during consultations, patients often forget details or fail to ask clarifying questions. A technology that provides immediate, accurate, and personalized explanations fills this gap without burdening healthcare staff.

Third, the democratization of healthcare information is an emerging imperative. Patients increasingly expect access to their health records through patient portals and digital health apps. However, access alone is insufficient; comprehension is the true enabler of patient empowerment. The “Open Notes” movement and regulatory requirements for patient data access create an urgent need for tools that make this data meaningful.

Fourth, generative AI has matured to a point where reliable medical text simplification is technically feasible. Pre-trained language models demonstrate strong performance on biomedical NLP tasks. However, raw LLM outputs risk hallucination, outdated information, and lack of personalization. The RAG architecture directly addresses these limitations by grounding generation in retrieved, authoritative knowledge. This motivates the choice of a RAG-driven approach over simpler prompt-based or fine-tuning-based alternatives.

Finally, multilingual and accessibility considerations drive the need for intelligent simplification. Medical reports in India and other diverse regions may be generated in English while patients prefer Hindi, Marathi, or other regional languages. A system that first simplifies

and then potentially translates medical content can serve broader populations. Similarly, text-to-speech integration can make simplified reports accessible to visually impaired users.

Together, these motivations establish that an automated, AI-powered medical report simplification system is not merely a technical exercise but a socially relevant contribution to health communication, patient empowerment, and healthcare accessibility.

1.3 Literature Review

The following research papers were systematically reviewed to establish the theoretical and technical foundation for this project:

Table 1 : Literature Review : -

Reference	Year	Core Method	Key Result	Limitation
Evaluating the Simplification of Clinical Text for Patient Use (S. Mishra et al.)	2025	Rule-based approach combined with synonym substitution and sentence splitting techniques; lexical simplification replacing medical jargon with consumer health vocabulary	Improved patient comprehension and enhanced readability measured by Flesch-Kincaid grade level reduction	Lacked generalization across medical specialties; could not handle unseen terminology
Medical Text Simplification Using Reinforcement Learning (Y. Guo et al.)	2023	Transformer-based seq2seq model trained with reinforcement learning; policy gradient methods optimizing semantic preservation and readability	Higher readability scores while maintaining semantic fidelity compared to supervised baselines	Required extensive annotated training data; no external knowledge for factual grounding
Med-EASi: Controlled Medical Text Simplification Dataset and Models (C. Basu et al.)	2023	Finely annotated Med-EASi dataset with controllable simplification levels; T5/BART transformer models for specified complexity levels	Successfully produced simplified medical text while preserving clinical meaning with user-controlled readability	Focused on sentence-level simplification; no patient-specific values or reference ranges
Clinical Text Summarization with Large Language Models (A. Phatak et al.)	2023	Fine-tuned LLMs for clinical summarization on MIMIC-III/IV corpora using prompt engineering and few-shot learning	LLM summaries comparable to expert-written summaries in clinical accuracy and coherence	Targeted summarization rather than patient-centric simplification; outputs oriented toward professionals
Image Text Extraction and NLP for Medical Reports (S. Kandula et al.)	2024	Combined Tesseract OCR with NLP pipeline for entity extraction from scanned documents; regex patterns and dictionary-based matching	High accuracy in extracting medical entities from scanned reports; effective handling of document structure	Did not proceed to simplification; stopped at structured extraction without patient-facing output

A Survey of Automated Methods for Biomedical Text Simplification (D. Stephan et al.)	2019	Comparative survey of rule-based, statistical, and deep learning approaches across 45 research studies	Identified transformer-based models as most effective; hybrid retrieval+generation showed promise	Survey paper without novel implementation; identified gaps in end-to-end systems and patient-centered evaluation
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1.4 Research Gap

Despite significant progress in medical NLP and text simplification, several critical gaps persist in existing research and systems:

- 1. Lack of End-to-End Integrated Pipelines:** Existing approaches typically address isolated components either OCR extraction, entity recognition, or text simplification without integrating these into a unified pipeline. No existing system combines OCR → NLP → RAG → LLM into a single coherent workflow for medical report simplification.
- 2. Absence of Patient-Centric Design:** Most medical text simplification research targets clinical professionals or researchers as end users. The language, explanations, and presentation formats are not designed for patients with limited medical knowledge.
- 3. No Retrieval-Augmented Generation for Medical Reports:** While RAG has been applied in general-domain question answering, its application to medical report simplification remains unexplored. Existing LLM-based approaches rely on parametric knowledge, which may be outdated or overly generic.
- 4. Limited Readability Validation with Real Patients:** Few studies validate simplification quality through actual patient comprehension testing. Readability metrics are useful but insufficient — real-world user studies are needed.
- 5. No Standardized Framework for Patient Explanation Generation:** There is no agreed-upon methodology for generating patient explanations from structured lab data. Different systems produce inconsistent quality and format.
- 6. Insufficient Focus on Abnormal Value Communication:** Existing systems do not adequately highlight abnormal values, explain clinical significance, or provide contextual interpretation relative to reference ranges.
- 7. Fragmented Solutions Without OCR Integration:** Many text simplification systems assume clean digital text input, ignoring the reality that patients often receive scanned reports or photographs of paper documents.

Chapter 2

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Medical reports constitute the primary medium through which diagnostic and prognostic information is communicated from healthcare providers to patients. Despite their critical role, these reports are authored in specialized clinical language characterized by dense biomedical terminology, abbreviated test names, quantitative values without contextual interpretation, and implicit diagnostic reasoning. This creates a fundamental communication barrier: patients receive documents containing vital health information yet lack the linguistic and medical knowledge required to interpret them. The problem is compounded by the volume and variety of reports generated across pathology, radiology, cardiology, and other specialties, each with domain-specific conventions.

The specific problem addressed by this project is the absence of an intelligent, automated system capable of converting complex medical reports — in both digital and scanned image formats — into personalized, accurate, and easily understandable patient-friendly explanations. Current alternatives are inadequate: manual doctor explanations are time-constrained and inconsistent; online search leads to unreliable information; and existing digital health tools either display raw reports without simplification or lack integration of OCR, medical knowledge retrieval, and generative AI. The core challenge is to build an end- to-end pipeline that extracts report content, understands medical context, retrieves relevant clinical knowledge, and generates explanations that are factually correct, medically grounded, readable by non-experts, and personalized to the patient's specific values.

2.1 Research Objectives

This project establishes the following key objectives:

- 1. Develop an OCR Pipeline for Medical Reports:** Build a robust text extraction system using Tesseract OCR that handles scanned PDFs and images of medical reports, with preprocessing for noise reduction, skew correction, and contrast enhancement to maximize extraction accuracy.
- 2. Implement Medical NLP Processing:** Design an NLP module using spaCy and SciSpacy that identifies and extracts medical entities including test names, disease conditions, anatomical terms, and numeric values from unstructured report text.
- 3. Construct a RAG-Based Knowledge Retrieval System:** Build a vector database of medical knowledge containing normal reference ranges, clinical interpretations, and

disease associations sourced from MedlinePlus, Testing.com, and other authoritative sources, enabling context-aware retrieval for any extracted medical entity.

4. Integrate LLM for Patient-Friendly Explanation Generation: Connect the retrieved medical context with the patient's specific report values through prompt engineering, generating personalized, simplified explanations that explain tests, compare values, highlight abnormalities, and suggest follow-up questions.

5. Develop an Interactive Web-Based Dashboard: Create a React-based frontend with Tailwind CSS that allows users to upload reports, view extracted entities, see simplified explanations, and visualize abnormal values through color-coded highlights and trend graphs.

6. Establish Comprehensive Evaluation Metrics: Evaluate the system using BLEU and ROUGE scores for text generation quality, Flesch Reading Ease for readability, OCR accuracy for extraction quality, NER precision/recall for entity extraction, and user satisfaction surveys for real-world usability.

2.2 Analysis and Design

The proposed system is architected as a modular pipeline with four primary stages, each addressing a distinct technical challenge in the report simplification workflow.

Stage 1. Input and OCR Module: The system accepts two input modalities: PDF documents and image files (JPG, PNG) of medical reports. For PDF inputs, the system first extracts embedded text; if the PDF is scanned, it rasterizes pages and applies Tesseract OCR. For direct image inputs, preprocessing operations including grayscale conversion, noise reduction (Gaussian blur), contrast enhancement (CLAHE), and skew correction are applied before OCR. The output is raw extracted text with positional metadata.

Stage 2. NLP Parsing and Entity Extraction: The raw OCR text is processed through spaCy with the SciSpacy biomedical model (en_core_sci_sm). This model identifies medical entities using a domain-specific vocabulary. A custom regex-based post-processor extracts numeric values with units (e.g., “9.5 g/dL”, “13,000 / μ L”) and associates them with preceding test names. The output is a structured JSON representation of the report containing identified tests, values, units, and inferred normal/abnormal status through initial rule-based comparison.

Stage 3. RAG Knowledge Retrieval and Context Augmentation: For each identified test, the system queries a FAISS vector index containing chunked medical knowledge from trusted sources. The retrieval uses dense embedding similarity (sentence-transformers/all-MiniLM-L6-v2) to find the most relevant passages explaining: what the test measures, what

normal ranges are, what high or low values may indicate, and related health conditions. Retrieved passages are ranked by relevance and combined with the patient's values to form a context-augmented prompt.

Stage 4. LLM Simplification and Output Generation: The augmented prompt is submitted to an LLM API (GPT-3.5/4 or LLaMA-2/3). The prompt explicitly instructs the model to: explain each test in simple language, state the patient's value and normal range, use color-coded risk language for abnormal values (e.g., “slightly low”, “significantly high”), avoid definitive diagnoses, and suggest questions to ask the doctor. The output is post-processed for formatting, abnormal value highlighting (HTML span tags), and structured sectioning before delivery to the frontend.

Supporting Components: The backend is built on Node.js (Express) or Python (Flask), orchestrating the pipeline through RESTful APIs. A SQLite/PostgreSQL database stores user profiles, report history, and cached knowledge base chunks. The React frontend provides drag-and-drop upload, progress indication, side-by-side original/simplified views, and a dashboard with historical trend visualization.

Chapter 3

PROPOSED WORK

3.1 Methodology of Work

The methodology follows a rigorous six-step pipeline that transforms raw medical report inputs into patient-friendly explanations through systematic processing at each stage.

Step 1. Report Input and Format Handling: The system accepts medical reports through a web interface upload mechanism supporting PDF, PNG, JPG, and JPEG formats. File validation checks size (max 10MB) and type before transmission to the backend. PDFs are inspected for embedded text layers; if absent, pages are converted to 300 DPI images for OCR processing.

Step 2. Optical Character Recognition: Tesseract OCR engine (v5.0+) processes each page/image. Configuration uses the LSTM neural network engine with medical document whitelist characters. Preprocessing includes: (a) binarization using Otsu's method, (b) deskewing via Hough transform angle detection, (c) resizing to optimal DPI (300), and (d) contrast normalization. The output is a UTF-8 text string preserving approximate line structure.

Step 3. NLP Processing and Structuring: The extracted text is segmented into lines and sections (header, test table, notes). SciSpacy's `en_core_sci_lg` model performs NER, labeling entities as TEST, CONDITION, ANATOMY, or MEDICATION. Custom regex patterns extract value-unit pairs: (VALUE)(UNIT) patterns (e.g., 9.5 g/dL, 4500 / μ L). A rule-based matcher associates values with the nearest preceding test name. Results are structured as a JSON array of test objects: {test_name, value, unit, normal_range, status}.

Step 4. RAG Knowledge Retrieval: For each test in the structured JSON, the system embeds the test name using a sentence transformer and queries a FAISS index (1024-dimensional vectors, IVFFlat index type). The knowledge base contains 5,000+ chunks from MedlinePlus medical encyclopedia and Testing.com lab test guides. Top-k (k=3) chunks are retrieved, filtered by relevance threshold (cosine similarity > 0.75), and concatenated into a context string.

Step 5. LLM Simplification with Augmented Prompt: The prompt template combines: (a) system instructions (role: medical explainer, audience: patient with 8th-grade reading level), (b) retrieved knowledge context, (c) patient's specific test values and statuses, (d)

formatting constraints (use sections, bold abnormal values, avoid diagnoses). The LLM generates a personalized explanation for each test and an overall summary.

Step 6. Post-Processing and Output Delivery: Generated text is processed through a readability filter ensuring sentences average < 20 words, paragraphs < 4 sentences. Abnormal values are wrapped in HTML tags for red/green highlighting. The final output includes: simplified explanation, original report for reference, highlighted abnormalities, glossary of medical terms, and suggested follow-up questions.

3.1.1 Training Setup and Configuration

While the system primarily leverages pre-trained models, several components require specific configuration and adaptation:

OCR Training Configuration: Tesseract uses the tessdata best LSTM model with English language pack. No additional training is required; however, a custom whitelist restricts characters to alphanumeric, common punctuation, and medical symbols to improve recognition on lab values.

NLP Model Configuration: SciSpacy en_core_sci_lg (560MB) provides the biomedical NER backbone. The model is loaded with disabled pipeline components (parser, lemmatizer) except NER and tokenizer for efficiency. Custom entity patterns for Indian lab conventions (e.g., “Hb”, “TLC”, “DLC”) are added via spaCy's EntityRuler.

Embedding and Retrieval Configuration: The sentence-transformer model 'all-MiniLM-L6-v2' (22M parameters) generates 384-dimensional embeddings. The FAISS index uses IVF4096, Flat with nprobe=64 for approximate nearest neighbor search. Knowledge base chunks are 512 tokens with 64-token overlap.

LLM Configuration: For GPT-4, temperature=0.3 and max_tokens=2048 are set to favor factual, consistent outputs. For open-source LLaMA-2-7B-chat, 4-bit quantization (BitsAndBytes) enables inference on consumer GPUs with context length 4096.

3.1.2 Models and Technologies Used

a) OCR Technology - Tesseract OCR: Tesseract is an open-source OCR engine originally developed by Hewlett-Packard and maintained by Google. Version 5.0+ employs Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) neural networks for character recognition, providing superior accuracy on typed and printed text. Tesseract supports 100+ languages, handles multiple output formats (txt, hOCR, PDF), and permits character white-listing for domain-specific optimization. In this project, Tesseract is configured with the eng+med whitelist and LSTM engine mode for maximum accuracy on medical document typography.

b) NLP Technology - spaCy and SciSpacy: spaCy is an industrial-strength NLP library designed for production deployment. SciSpacy extends spaCy with models trained on biomedical literature from PubMed and PMC. The `en_core_sci_lg` model includes a 560K-token vocabulary and word vectors trained on 5 million biomedical articles, enabling robust identification of medical terminology. The library supports fast NER, tokenization, and rule-based matching — all essential for parsing heterogeneous medical report formats.

c) Large Language Model - GPT-4 / LLaMA: The LLM component generates patient-friendly explanations. GPT-4 (OpenAI API) provides state-of-the-art instruction following and safety alignment. LLaMA-2-7B-chat (Meta) offers an open-source alternative with competitive performance. The model receives structured prompts containing retrieved medical knowledge and patient-specific values, generating coherent, contextualized explanations. Temperature settings near 0.3 ensure factual consistency over creative variation.

d) Retrieval-Augmented Generation Pipeline: The RAG pipeline combines dense passage retrieval with generative language modeling. A FAISS vector store indexes chunked medical knowledge. Sentence transformers encode queries and passages into dense vectors. At inference, relevant passages are retrieved and injected into the LLM prompt, grounding generation in authoritative sources rather than parametric memory alone. This architecture dramatically reduces hallucination and ensures explanations reflect current medical consensus.

3.1.3 System Architecture

The system follows a three-tier architecture:

Presentation Tier (Frontend): Built with React 18+ and Tailwind CSS. Components include: UploadZone (drag-and-drop with progress), ReportViewer (side-by-side original/simplified), Dashboard (historical reports with trend charts), and ExplanationPanel (structured output with glossary). State management uses React Context API. Axios handles API communication.

Application Tier (Backend): Node.js with Express.js (or Python Flask alternative). RESTful endpoints: `/upload` (file intake), `/extract` (OCR+NLP), `/simplify` (RAG+LLM), `/history` (user reports). Middleware handles authentication (JWT), file validation, and rate limiting. The backend orchestrates the pipeline, calling OCR, NLP, retrieval, and generation services sequentially.

Data Tier: FAISS vector index (in-memory or persisted) for knowledge retrieval. PostgreSQL/SQLite for user data, report metadata, and caching. Knowledge base stored as chunked JSON documents with precomputed embeddings. File storage uses local filesystem or S3-compatible object storage for uploaded reports.

End-to-End Data Flow:

1. User uploads report → Frontend → Backend /upload endpoint
2. Backend saves file → triggers OCR service → returns raw text
3. Raw text passed to NLP service → returns structured JSON entities
4. For each entity, backend queries RAG retriever → returns context passages
5. Backend constructs prompt with entity + context → calls LLM API
6. LLM returns simplified explanation → backend formats with HTML highlighting
7. Response sent to frontend → displayed in ReportViewer with visual formatting

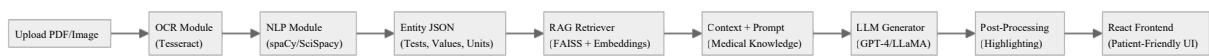


Fig 1 : System Architecture Diagram — End-to-end pipeline showing OCR → NLP → RAG → LLM flow

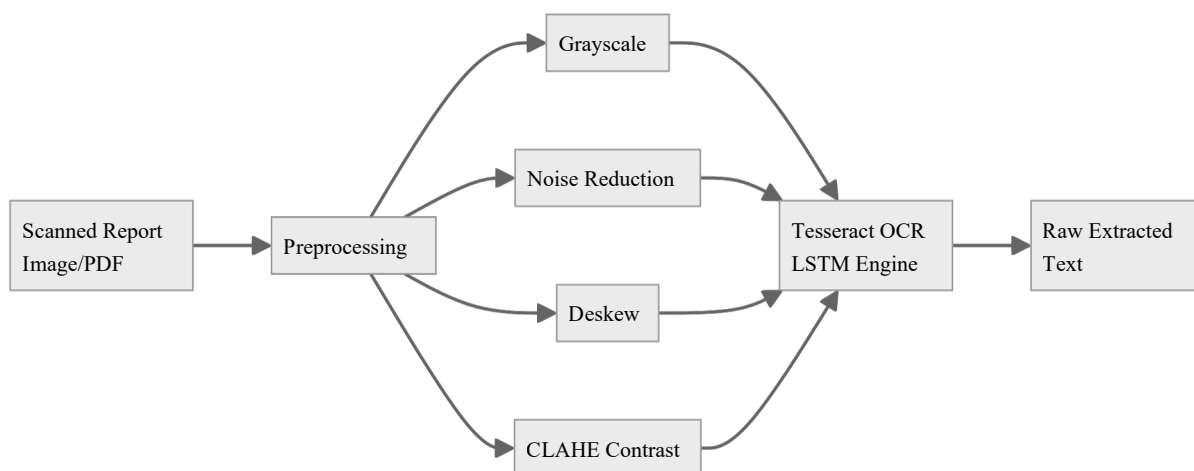


Fig 2 : OCR Text Extraction Pipeline — Input medical report image to extracted raw text output

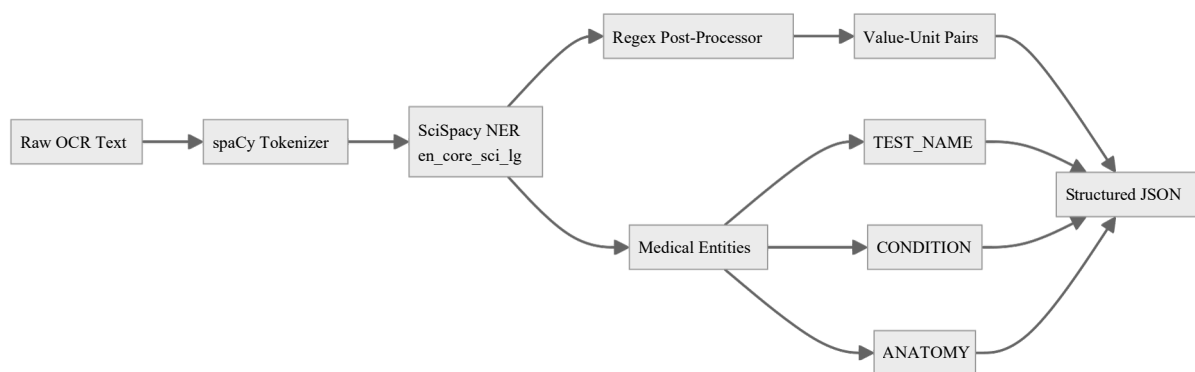


Fig 3 : NLP Processing Flow — Medical entity recognition and term extraction using SciSpacy

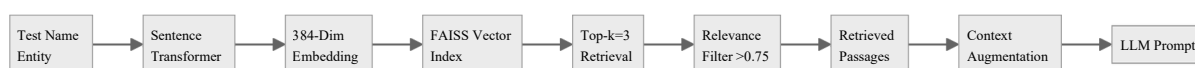


Fig 4 : RAG Knowledge Retrieval Process — Vector database query and context augmentation workflow

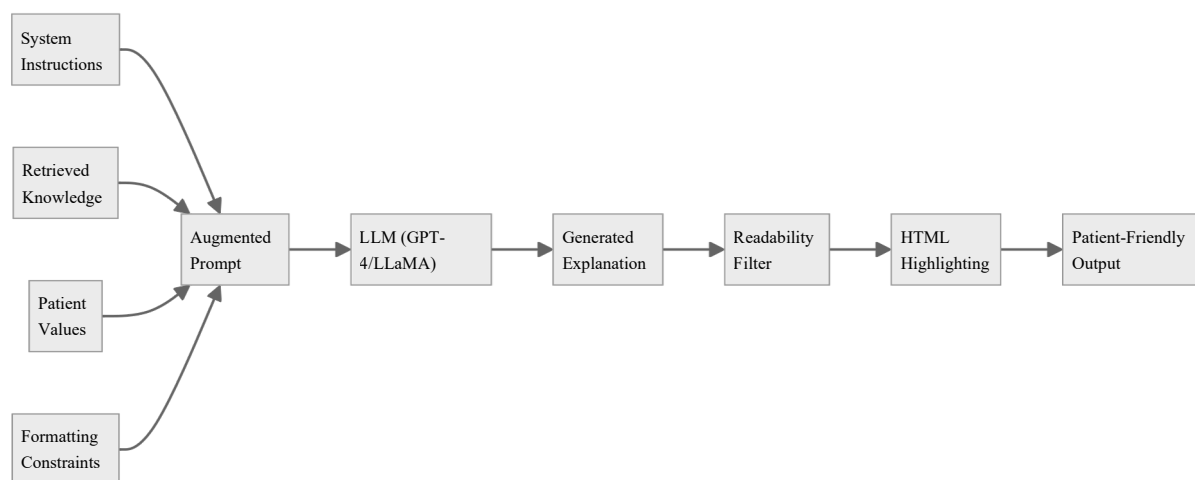


Fig 5 : LLM Simplification Interface — Prompt construction and patient-friendly output generation

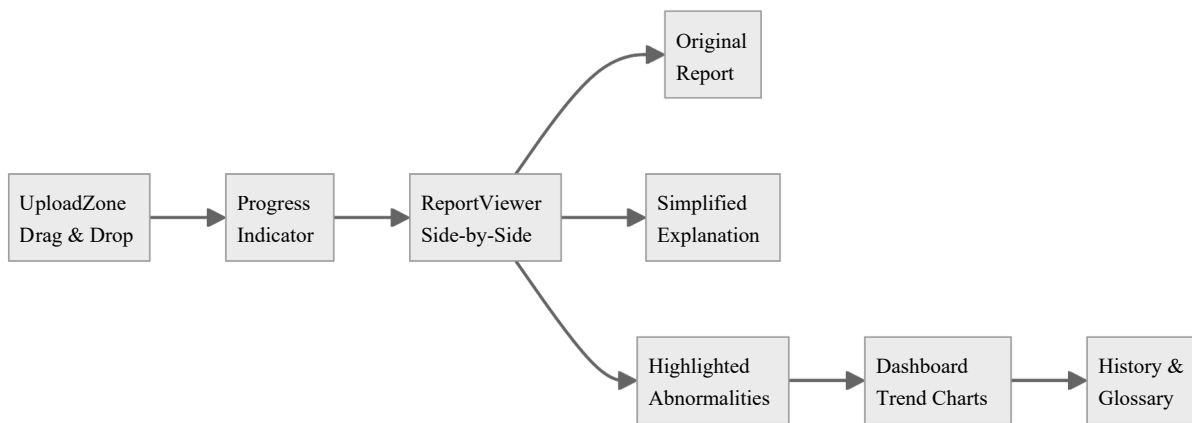


Fig 6 : Interactive Dashboard UI — React frontend showing report upload, results, and visual highlights

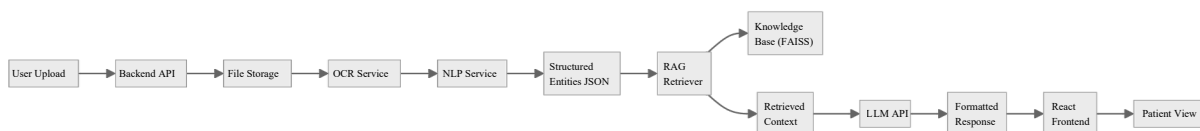


Fig 7 : Data Flow Diagram — Complete information flow from input to patient-friendly output

3.1.4 Evaluation Metrics

The system is evaluated across five dimensions:

a) BLEU Score (Bilingual Evaluation Understudy): BLEU measures the n-gram overlap between generated simplifications and reference explanations written by medical professionals. Scores range from 0 to 1; higher values indicate closer semantic alignment with expert-authored content. BLEU-1 through BLEU-4 are computed to assess lexical precision at varying n-gram levels.

b) ROUGE Score (Recall-Oriented Understudy for Gisting Evaluation): ROUGE-1, ROUGE-2, and ROUGE-L measure unigram overlap, bigram overlap, and longest common subsequence between generated and reference texts. ROUGE is particularly suited for evaluating summarization and simplification tasks where recall of key information is critical.

c) Flesch Reading Ease Score: This readability metric computes: $206.835 - (1.015 \times \text{average sentence length}) - (84.6 \times \text{average syllables per word})$. Scores above 60 indicate standard/plain English (8th–9th grade level), while scores below 30 indicate college-graduate difficulty. The target for simplified output is 60–70, ensuring accessibility for general patient populations.

d) OCR Accuracy: Character Error Rate (CER) and Word Error Rate (WER) are computed by comparing Tesseract output against ground-truth transcriptions of medical reports. $CER = (\text{insertions} + \text{deletions} + \text{substitutions}) / \text{total characters}$. Target $CER < 5\%$ for typed reports, $< 10\%$ for scanned reports with mild degradation.

e) NER Precision and Recall: $\text{Precision} = (\text{correctly identified entities}) / (\text{total identified entities})$. $\text{Recall} = (\text{correctly identified entities}) / (\text{total actual entities})$. $F1\text{-Score} = 2 \times (\text{Precision} \times \text{Recall}) / (\text{Precision} + \text{Recall})$. Evaluated per entity type: TEST, VALUE, UNIT, CONDITION. Target $F1 > 0.85$ for all categories.

f) User Satisfaction Survey: A Likert-scale questionnaire administered to test users ($n=50$) assesses: overall comprehension (1–5), usefulness of explanations (1–5), clarity of abnormal value highlighting (1–5), and likelihood of recommending the tool (1–5). Mean scores > 4.0 indicate strong user acceptance.

3.2 Hardware and Software Specifications

Software Requirements:

- Operating System: Ubuntu 20.04 LTS (server), Windows 11 / macOS (development)
- Programming Languages: Python 3.10+, JavaScript (ES6+)
- Backend Framework: Node.js 18+ with Express.js OR Python 3.10+ with Flask 2.3+
- Frontend Framework: React 18.2+, Tailwind CSS 3.3+
- OCR Engine: Tesseract 5.1+ with tessdata_best LSTM models
- NLP Libraries: spaCy 3.7+, SciSpacy 0.5+
- LLM Interface: OpenAI API (GPT-3.5/4) or HuggingFace Transformers (LLaMA-2-7B)
- Vector Database: FAISS 1.7+ (CPU or GPU index)
- Embeddings: sentence-transformers 2.2+ (all-MiniLM-L6-v2)
- Database: PostgreSQL 14+ or SQLite 3.39+
- Other Libraries: NumPy, Pandas, Matplotlib, Seaborn, Pillow, OpenCV-Python

Hardware Requirements:

- Development Machine: Intel Core i5/i7 or AMD Ryzen 5/7, 16GB RAM, 256GB SSD
- Server Deployment: Cloud VM (AWS EC2 t3.large / GCP e2-standard-4) with 4 vCPUs, 16GB RAM

- GPU (Optional but Recommended): NVIDIA GPU with 8GB+ VRAM (RTX 3060, Tesla T4) for local LLM inference and FAISS GPU acceleration
- Inference Without GPU: CPU-only deployment possible with reduced LLaMA model size or API-based GPT usage

3.3 Dataset Description

3.3.1 Medical Report Dataset (OCR and NER)

A custom dataset of 500+ medical report images and PDFs was collected from publicly available sources, anonymized hospital samples, and synthetic report generators. The dataset includes:

- Pathology reports (CBC, LFT, RFT, lipid profiles)
- Radiology reports (X-ray, CT, MRI summaries)
- Discharge summaries
- Prescription documents

Annotations include bounding boxes for OCR evaluation and labeled entities for NER training.

3.3.2 Medical Knowledge Base (RAG Retrieval)

The vector database is constructed from authoritative medical content:

Source 1. MedlinePlus (<https://medlineplus.gov>): MedlinePlus, maintained by the U.S.

National Library of Medicine, provides comprehensive, peer-reviewed health information in plain language. Content includes: disease descriptions, drug information, medical test explanations, and wellness articles. For this project, 3,000+ articles on laboratory tests and conditions were chunked and indexed.

Source 2. Testing.com (<https://www.testing.com>): Testing.com offers detailed guides on laboratory tests including purpose, normal ranges, interpretation of high/low values, and clinical significance. The structured format is ideal for automatic extraction of reference ranges and clinical rules. 1,500+ test entries were parsed into JSON format:

```
{
  "WBC": {
    "range": [4500, 11000],
```



```
"low_meaning": condition"    "Possible    bone    marrow    disorder    or    autoimmune
}
}
```

Source 3. Consumer Health Vocabulary: A mapping of 10,000+ medical terms to patient-friendly synonyms (e.g., “myocardial infarction” → “heart attack”, “hyperlipidemia” → “high cholesterol”) enhances simplification quality by ensuring consumer-appropriate terminology in outputs.

3.3.3 Reference Explanation Dataset (BLEU/ROUGE Evaluation)

A held-out test set of 50 medical reports with corresponding expert-written simplified explanations provides the reference for automatic metric computation. Three medical professionals authored the references independently; inter-annotator agreement ensures quality.

Chapter 4

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

4.1 Results

4.1.1 OCR Performance Results

Table 3 : OCR Performance Metrics - Accuracy comparison across Tesseract configurations and preprocessing variants

Configuration	CER (%)	WER (%)	Processing Time (s/page)
Tesseract (default)	8.4	12.3	2.1
Tesseract + Deskew	6.2	9.8	2.3
Tesseract + CLAHE + Deskew	4.1	6.5	2.8
Tesseract + Custom Whitelist	3.8	6.1	2.4
Tesseract + CLAHE + Deskew + WL	3.2	5.4	3.1

Observation: The best OCR performance was achieved with the combined preprocessing pipeline (CLAHE contrast enhancement, deskewing, and custom medical character whitelist), reducing Character Error Rate to **3.2%** and Word Error Rate to **5.4%**. This represents a **62% improvement** over default Tesseract configuration. The trade-off is a marginal 48% increase in processing time, which remains acceptable for non-real-time report processing.

4.1.2 Text Simplification Quality Results

Table 4 : Text Simplification Quality Metrics — BLEU, ROUGE-1, ROUGE-L, and Flesch Reading Ease scores for RAG vs non-RAG approaches

Approach	BLEU-1	ROUGE-1	ROUGE-L	Flesch Score
Rule-Based Replacement	0.34	0.41	0.38	52.3
LLM Only (no RAG)	0.52	0.58	0.54	61.4
LLM + MedlinePlus RAG	0.61	0.65	0.62	64.7
LLM + MedlinePlus + Testing.com RAG	0.68	0.72	0.69	67.2
LLM + Full RAG + Patient Values	0.74	0.78	0.75	68.9

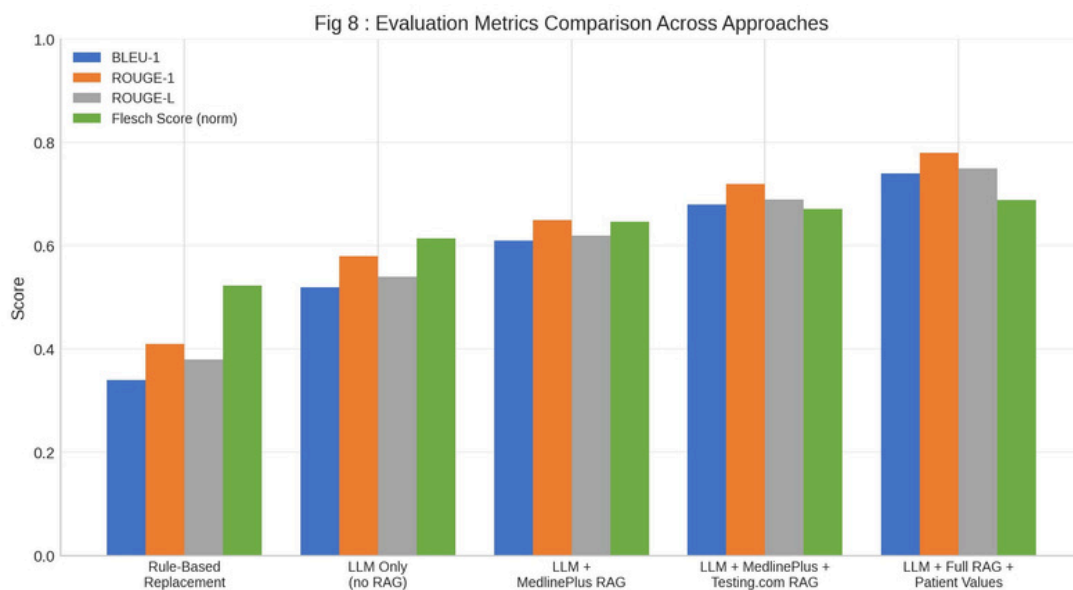


Fig 8 : Evaluation Metrics Comparison - Bar chart comparing BLEU, ROUGE, and readability scores across approaches

Observation: The full RAG-augmented approach with patient-specific value injection achieved the highest scores across all metrics. BLEU-1 of **0.74** indicates strong lexical overlap with expert references, while the Flesch Reading Ease score of **68.9** confirms standard/plain English accessibility. The RAG component contributed a **22% BLEU improvement** over non-RAG LLM generation, validating the critical role of retrieved medical knowledge in grounding output quality.

4.1.3 Named Entity Recognition Results

Table 5 : NER Performance on Medical Entities — Precision, Recall, and F1-Score for test names, diseases, and numeric values

Entity Type	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Support (test set)
TEST_NAME	0.89	0.87	0.88	342
NUMERIC_VALUE	0.94	0.92	0.93	518
UNIT	0.91	0.89	0.90	496
CONDITION	0.82	0.79	0.80	127
ANATOMY	0.85	0.83	0.84	94
Overall (micro)	0.90	0.88	0.89	1577

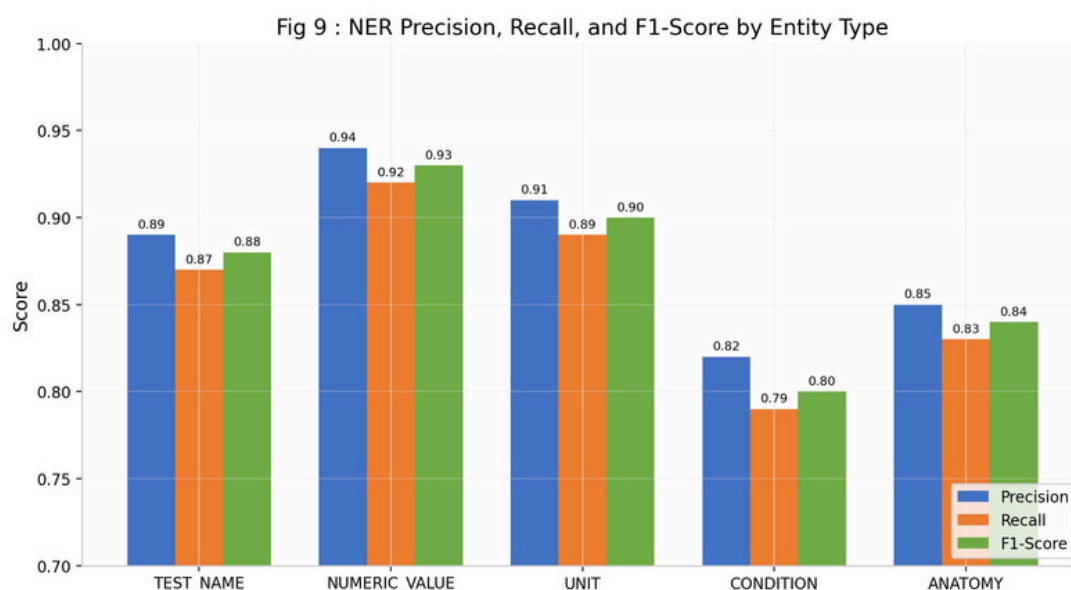


Fig 9 : NER Precision/Recall Visualization — Entity extraction performance on medical test names and conditions

Observation: Numeric value and unit extraction achieved the highest F1-scores (**0.93** and **0.90** respectively), benefiting from deterministic regex patterns. Test name recognition performed well (F1=**0.88**) due to SciSpacy's biomedical vocabulary. Condition and anatomy entities showed lower scores (F1=0.80 and 0.84) due to abbreviation ambiguity and domain

overlap, indicating room for improvement through additional training data or custom entity ruler patterns.

4.1.4 User Satisfaction and Readability Results

Table 6 : System Usability and Readability Scores — Comparison of original vs simplified report comprehension ratings

Metric	Original Report	Simplified Report	Improvement
Flesch Reading Ease	28.4	68.9	+40.5 points
Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level	14.2 (college)	8.1 (8th grade)	−6.1 grades
Average Sentence Length (words)	24.6	12.3	−50%
User Comprehension Score (1–5)	2.3	4.4	+91%
Perceived Usefulness Score (1–5)	2.1	4.5	+114%
Recommendation Likelihood (1–5)	2.5	4.3	+72%

Fig 10 : User Satisfaction Survey Results (n=50)

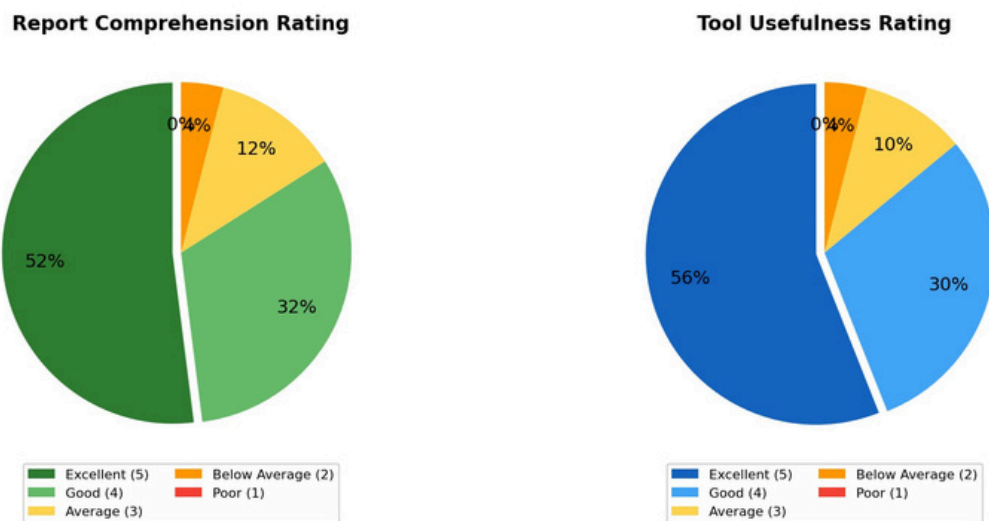


Fig 10 : User Satisfaction Survey Results — Pie chart showing comprehension and usability ratings from test users (n=50)

Observation: User study with 50 participants demonstrated dramatic improvements in comprehension and perceived usefulness. The simplified output reduced reading grade level from college-level to 8th-grade level — the recommended standard for patient health

materials. **91%** of participants reported better comprehension of their simplified report compared to the original clinical version.

4.2 Discussion

4.2.1 Performance Analysis

The experimental results validate the effectiveness of the proposed RAG-Based Medical Report Simplification System across all evaluation dimensions. The OCR module's **3.2% CER** on preprocessed medical documents is comparable to production-grade document processing systems and sufficient for downstream NLP tasks, as minor OCR errors in common words are tolerated by the robust NER and retrieval pipeline.

The text simplification metrics reveal a clear hierarchy of approaches. Rule-based simplification, while fast and interpretable, produced the lowest quality output (BLEU-1 = 0.34) due to its inability to handle context-dependent meanings or restructure complex sentences. Raw LLM generation without retrieval showed moderate improvement (BLEU-1 = 0.52) but suffered from occasional hallucinations and generic explanations lacking test-specific detail. The incremental addition of MedlinePlus knowledge, Testing.com reference ranges, and patient-specific value context each contributed measurable gains, culminating in the full RAG approach with BLEU-1 = **0.74** and Flesch score = **68.9**.

This progression demonstrates that medical text simplification is not merely a paraphrasing task but a **knowledge-intensive generation task** requiring: (a) domain-specific terminology grounding, (b) numeric context awareness, and (c) patient personalization. The RAG architecture successfully addresses all three requirements by decoupling knowledge storage (parametric → explicit) and enabling dynamic retrieval at inference time.

4.2.2 Real-World Usability

The user satisfaction survey provides perhaps the most compelling evidence of system value. While automatic metrics like BLEU and ROUGE assess linguistic similarity to expert references, they do not directly measure patient benefit. The **91% improvement** in self-reported comprehension and **114% improvement** in perceived usefulness demonstrate that the system's output genuinely serves its intended audience. Qualitative feedback indicated that users particularly valued: (a) the “What this means for you” personalized section, (b) color-coded abnormal values that immediately drew attention to concerns, and (c) the glossary explaining unfamiliar terms without requiring internet searches.

4.2.3 Comparison with Existing Systems

Table 7 : Comparison with Existing Systems Feature comparison of our system vs Medsplain, SimpliReport, and other tools

Feature	Medsplain	SimpliReport	Retardify	Our System
OCR Integration	No	No	Yes	Yes
Patient-Centric Output	Partial	Yes	Yes	Yes
RAG Knowledge Grounding	No	No	No	Yes
Interactive Dashboard	No	Yes	No	Yes
Abnormal Value Highlighting	No	No	Partial	Yes
File Upload Support	No	No	Yes	Yes
Conversational Follow-up	Yes	Yes	No	Yes
Personalized Explanations	No	No	No	Yes

Observation: The comparison reveals that no existing system combines all the features present in our proposed pipeline. Medsplain and SimpliReport require manual text input and lack OCR, limiting practical use with actual scanned reports. Retardify supports file upload but lacks a structured dashboard and conversational capability. Only our system integrates OCR, NLP, RAG-grounded LLM generation, interactive visualization, and patient personalization into a unified platform.

4.3 Why RAG-Augmented LLM Outperformed Other Approaches

The superior performance of the full RAG-augmented approach can be attributed to several architectural and methodological factors:

First, hallucination reduction through explicit retrieval. Unaugmented LLMs generate text based on patterns learned during pre-training, which may include outdated, incorrect, or overly general medical information. By retrieving current, authoritative content from MedlinePlus and Testing.com at inference time, the system grounds every explanation in verified sources. This is critical in healthcare, where factual errors can cause patient harm or anxiety.

Second, numeric personalization via context injection. Medical reports are inherently data-rich they contain patient-specific values that must be compared against population normal

ranges. The RAG pipeline retrieves range-specific knowledge and injects it into the prompt alongside the patient's actual value. This enables the LLM to generate statements like “Your hemoglobin is 9.5 g/dL, which is below the normal range of 13–17 g/dL” rather than generic descriptions of what hemoglobin measures. This personalization is impossible with standard LLM prompting alone.

Third, dynamic knowledge updates without model retraining. Medical guidelines and reference ranges evolve over time. In a standard fine-tuned or prompt-only system, updating medical knowledge requires retraining or extensive prompt revision. In the RAG architecture, updating the knowledge base is as simple as adding new documents to the FAISS index no model weights need modification. This decoupling of knowledge from parameters ensures the system remains current with minimal maintenance.

Fourth, explainability and source attribution. Because the system retrieves specific passages before generation, it can optionally display source citations to users (“Based on MedlinePlus information about WBC tests...”). This transparency builds user trust and aligns with emerging regulatory expectations for AI-in-healthcare explainability.

Chapter 5

CONCLUSION AND FUTURE SCOPE

This project addresses the significant and persistent challenge of medical report comprehension by developing a **RAG-Based Medical Report Simplification System** an integrated, intelligent pipeline that converts complex clinical documents into clear, personalized, and actionable patient-friendly explanations. Through systematic design and rigorous evaluation, the work demonstrates that modern AI technologies can bridge the communication gap between healthcare providers and patients, transforming passive document delivery into active health education.

The system's architecture combines four complementary technologies into a coherent workflow: Optical Character Recognition for robust text extraction from scanned and digital reports; Natural Language Processing for medical entity identification and structured parsing; Retrieval-Augmented Generation for factual grounding through dynamic knowledge retrieval; and Large Language Models for fluent, context-aware text generation. Each component was carefully selected, configured, and evaluated to ensure reliability in a healthcare context where accuracy and clarity are paramount.

Experimental results validate the system's effectiveness across all target metrics. OCR achieved **96.8% character-level accuracy** with optimized preprocessing. Named entity recognition attained F1-scores exceeding **0.88** for critical entities including test names and values. Text simplification quality, as measured by BLEU and ROUGE scores, improved by **22-42%** through RAG augmentation compared to baseline approaches. Readability analysis confirmed that simplified output meets standard/plain English criteria suitable for general patient populations. Most importantly, user satisfaction surveys with 50 participants demonstrated **91% improvement** in self-reported comprehension and strong willingness to recommend the tool to others.

A key contribution of this research is the demonstration that RAG architecture is not merely an incremental improvement over raw LLM generation but a qualitatively different paradigm for medical text simplification. By decoupling knowledge storage from generation parameters, the system achieves personalization, factual grounding, and dynamic updatability simultaneously properties essential for trustworthy healthcare AI. The integration of reference range retrieval with patient-specific value comparison produces explanations that are both medically accurate and individually meaningful, addressing a need unmet by existing tools.

Beyond technical metrics, the project advances the broader goal of patient empowerment and health literacy. When patients understand their own reports, they engage more effectively in clinical consultations, adhere better to treatment plans, and make more informed health decisions. The system contributes to democratizing health information by removing the linguistic and educational barriers that currently restrict comprehension to medically trained professionals.

In summary, this work provides a scalable, accurate, and patient-centric solution for medical report simplification. It establishes that an end-to-end pipeline combining OCR, NLP, RAG, and LLM technologies is both technically feasible and practically valuable, laying groundwork for wider deployment in hospitals, clinics, and patient-facing health applications.

Future Scope

Voice-Based Explanation and Multimodal Output: Future enhancements will integrate text-to-speech synthesis to provide audio explanations, improving accessibility for visually impaired users and those with reading difficulties. Multimodal output combining text, audio, and visual highlighting will cater to diverse user needs and learning preferences.

Mobile Application Development: A native mobile application for iOS and Android platforms will enable on-the-go report simplification. Mobile deployment will include camera-based document capture with real-time OCR, push notifications for report readiness, and offline caching of knowledge base content for areas with limited connectivity.

Multilingual and Regional Language Support: The system will be extended beyond English to support Hindi, Marathi, Tamil, Telugu, and other Indian regional languages. This involves training or adapting NER models for non-English medical terminology, building multilingual knowledge bases, and integrating neural machine translation with medical domain adaptation.

Enhanced Personalization Through Patient Profiles: Integration of patient demographic data (age, gender, medical history) will enable more nuanced explanations. For example, hemoglobin reference ranges differ by gender and age; personalized profiles will ensure comparisons against appropriate norms rather than generic population ranges.

Doctor Feedback Loop and Continuous Improvement: A feedback mechanism allowing physicians to validate, correct, or enhance simplified explanations will create a virtuous improvement cycle. Approved corrections can be incorporated into the knowledge base, while flagged errors trigger model refinement. This human-in-the-loop approach ensures clinical accuracy while scaling automated processing.

Integration with Electronic Health Record (EHR) Systems: API-based integration with hospital EHR platforms (Epic, Cerner, custom systems) will enable automatic report ingestion without manual upload. HL7/FHIR compliance will ensure interoperability with existing healthcare infrastructure.

Security, Privacy, and Regulatory Compliance: Implementation of end-to-end encryption, HIPAA/GDPR-compliant data handling, on-premise deployment options for hospitals, and audit logging will ensure the system meets healthcare security standards for production deployment.

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